

Alsatia

No. 142

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

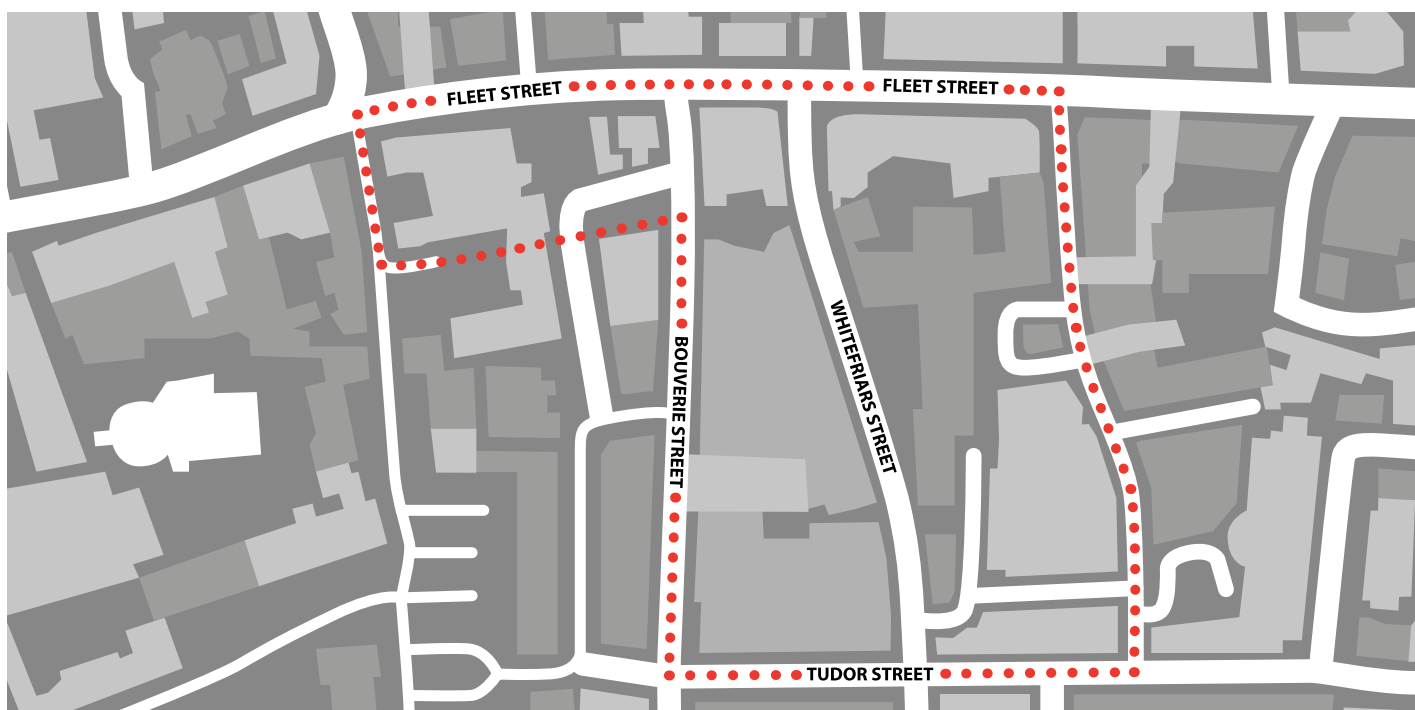
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From the 1670s to 1697, the area between Fleet Street and the Thames was known as Alsatia. It became a refuge for debtors escaping prison and included Whitefriars, Salisbury Court, Ram Alley and Mitre Court. Across the river in Southwark were similar sanctuary areas, including The Mint and The Clink. The name came from the French region of Alsace.

From 1352, people who could not pay their debts could be imprisoned, often in harsh conditions. Some churches and special liberties, including Whitefriars, offered sanctuary from arrest.

Alsatia was also known for its theatres and featured in Thomas Shadwell's *The Squire of Alsatia*, which portrayed its residents as rogues and imposters.

In 1691, a riot broke out between the Alsatians and lawyers from the Temple. After order was restored and Captain Francis Winter was executed outside Whitefriars, the government passed the 1697 Escape from Prisons Act, ending Alsatia and other sanctuary areas.



The map shows the approximate boundaries of Alsatia on today's street plan. In the seventeenth century, Alsatia reached the banks of the River Thames, before the Embankment was built. It also included several separate areas (not shown on the map): the Savoy, Fullers Rents (now Fulwood Place), and Baldwin's Rents (now Baldwin's Gardens).